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REBECOMING: THE LATEST MODEL



A memoir, restructured

BY MK PARRISH

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A note before we start

Most books that promise to change you open with a promise and close with a worksheet. This one has no worksheet. It has a QR code, a flight of rain-dark church steps, eleven minutes I almost spend walking the other way, and (this is the part I most want you to hear) a roomful of women who became, against every prediction I ever made about my life, the great loves of it. I find the code by accident, the way the important things tend to arrive, while I am looking for something else entirely. After that, nothing in my life ever sits in quite the same place again.

I want to tell you what I found on the other side of that door, because somebody told you a story about it that isn't true. They told you the door was for a certain kind of person. They told you what kind of woman walks through it, and what kind of woman doesn't, and they let you assume, without ever quite saying it, which kind you are. I believed that story for most of my life. I am writing this book to take it apart in front of you, gently, one beam at a time, and then to show you what's actually inside: friendship with no audition, love with no invoice, and a hope I had genuinely stopped believing was still in stock for someone like me.

I am a Pisces and a poet and a lifelong insomniac and, it turns out, an empath and a highly sensitive person, which together mean I feel everything at a volume the world keeps calling a malfunction. For years I am certain that if I think hard enough and stay up late enough, I can out-argue my own fear. I cannot. You do not think your way out of a feeling. You walk through the middle of it, and it helps, more than I can tell you, to find that someone has gone ahead, is holding the door, and has already set out a chair with your name on it.

Two of the people who told me I had a story worth telling are gone now. I am telling it anyway. This is me, finally, telling it.

PART ONE: THE QR CODE

It's raining by the time I reach the church, and I stand at the bottom of the steps for eleven minutes without going up them.

I know it's eleven because I watch each one turn over on my phone, the same small lit rectangle that carried me here, the same one that holds the whole shouting world, the way you watch a kettle you are praying won't boil. When you don't own a car, you arrive at things on foot and on time and with no armor at all. There's no idling at the curb with the heater running. No metal shell to hide inside while you quietly lose your nerve. There is only me, and the cold coming up through the thin soles of my shoes, and the gray Saturday going wet and silver around my shoulders, and a lit doorway forty feet up and to the left that might as well be set in the far wall of an ocean.

Let me put you exactly where I am, because the where of it matters. The stone under my feet is dark and slick and veined with rain, each step holding its own thin sheet of water that breaks and re-forms when the wind moves over it. The handrail is beaded silver, too cold to want to touch. The brass plate beside the door has gone green at its edges and bright where a thousand hands have worn it. Somewhere up there a candle is going. I can't see it yet, but I'll learn the smell of it in a minute and spend the rest of my life loving it. The bulletin is folding to pulp in my fist. My breath is going halfway down and stopping, the way it has been stopping for years.

I have a speech ready. I walked the whole way over rehearsing it, a small, reasonable, beautifully constructed case for why this particular morning is not the morning. I'm tired. I have a Saturday's worth of errands I could hide

inside of for hours. My dog needs me, which is a lie, because Biggie has been unconscious on the good pillow since breakfast and treats my entire existence as a mild interruption to his sleep.

But underneath the speech sits the real reason, and it's wearing a costume I know by heart. It leans in close, in my own voice, the most trusted voice I've got, and it says: *you are not the kind of woman who goes to Bible study.*

And here is where I have to stop and show you the picture, because the picture is the whole problem, and I carried it for so long I forgot it was a picture at all. A certain kind of woman with a certain kind of certainty. Women who had never once lain awake at two in the morning doubting the floor of the universe. Women in a tidy row who would look at the wreckage of me and quietly, charitably, thank God they'd been spared it. A panel of judges. A club I had failed to qualify for without ever once filling out the form. I'd held that picture for years, fully formed, never examined, the way you can carry an opinion your entire life without ever asking where you picked it up or whether it was ever yours.

That picture is the stigma. And I want to be very clear with you, this early, about what I learned: the picture was never describing the room. It was only ever describing my fear of the room. The two have almost nothing to do with each other, and learning the difference is going to cost me eleven minutes in the rain and then save the rest of my life.

Then the rain stops pretending. It comes down all at once: fat, cold, deliberate, drumming the steps and darkening the stone two shades and running the ink on the bulletin clean off the page and into my palm in little gray rivers, and it pushes me up the steps and through the door. Partly by grace. Partly because I will not come apart on a public sidewalk like a woman in the third act of a film no one agreed to make.

And before I can second-guess a single thing, before the heavy door has even finished sighing shut behind me on its slow brass hinge, before I've wiped the rain from my eyes, she is there.

The group leader. She crosses the room toward me the way dawn crosses a field, unhurried and total, and she doesn't offer me a hand to shake and she doesn't ask my name first and she doesn't give me a moment to arrange my face into something braver than it is. She simply opens both arms and folds me into a hug so complete, so unhesitating, that for one whole second I forget that I am a stranger, that I am soaked through, that I am afraid. She holds on like she has been saving this exact embrace all morning and has only just now found who it belonged to.

And she is *warm*. Actually warm: radiant the way a lit window is warm seen from a freezing street, the way the inside of a cupped hand is warm. Over her shoulder the whole room seems to lean toward her, the low lamplight pooling gold around her hair until I half expect to find it gilded, haloed, leafed like the saints in the side chapels of my girlhood, the ones behind the racks of flickering votives, faces tilted, ringed in beaten gold. She glows. I am not reaching for a metaphor; or I am, but it is also simply, plainly, what I see. She lights the room the way one candle lights a shrine, not by flooding it, but by giving every shadow in it somewhere gentle to go and lie down. *Angelic* is the word that arrives, fully formed, and I do not bother hunting for a better one, because there isn't one, and I have spent my whole life hunting for better words.

And into my wet hair, soft, like it is the simplest and most settled fact in the world, she says: *"You came. You already did it."*

You already did it.

The room takes apart every other thing I carried in out of the weather. I had braced for fluorescent glare; I get low gold lamplight instead, pooling warm on a dozen faces and catching in the steam rising off our wet coats. I had braced for folding-table bleakness, for the squeak of metal and the smell of industrial carpet; I get worn wood gone honey-colored under decades of hands, and candle wax, and old paper, and rain-damp wool, and the deep soft dust of a building that has kept a great many frightened people warm over a great many years. A radiator ticks somewhere along the wall, settling, like the room itself is breathing. Rain runs sideways down

the dark windows and the lamplight turns each track of it gold. I came ready to *endure* something. Instead, almost against my own will, every cell in me wants to stay.

There are twelve of us. A college sophomore with her sleeves pulled all the way down over her hands, her knee going under the table. A woman much further along, silver-haired and still as a held breath, who looks as though she has buried a couple of husbands and kept most of their secrets out of plain good manners. Women in the middle, like me, composed on the outside, immaculate, carrying things on the inside we have never once said out loud to anyone living.

And no one makes it strange. That's the second miracle of the morning, and I've learned since not to rank my miracles by size. The woman who settles in beside me slides her own copy of the book across the table toward me, open, and I look down and the margins are *crowded*. Underlines. Question marks. Whole sentences boxed and starred and argued with in three different colors of ink, the pages soft and furred at the corners from being turned and turned. She doesn't slide me a clean book. She slides me her mess. And that, it turns out, is the real invitation: not *here is the answer*, but *here is how unfinished I still am; come be unfinished beside me*.

I think about the prodigal son the whole way home, in a way I haven't in years. Everyone remembers the homecoming, the robe, the ring, the fattened calf, the father hitching up his good clothes to run flat-out down the road. But I keep landing on the part that comes first, the part nobody paints. The son is still a long way off. Still in the mud. Still rank with pig. He hasn't been forgiven yet and has no idea how any of it will land, and he gets up anyway, and turns toward home, and starts to walk.

There's a word for that turn. The old Greek for it is *metanoia*, and we usually translate it as *repentance*, which sounds like sackcloth and apology. But it doesn't mean groveling. It means, almost literally, *to turn the*

mind around. To be walking one direction and to stop, and to turn, and to start walking the other. That's it. That's the whole of it. Not arrival. Not certainty. Just the turn.

Nobody puts that part in stained glass. The turning around. The eleven minutes at the bottom of the steps. The thumb hovering over a small square of black and white. The stranger's arms closing around you before you've even said your name.

I haven't arrived anywhere yet. I've only turned around and started walking home. It is going to take me a long time, most of this book, to understand that the turn *is* the thing. That it was always the thing. That she was right, there in the doorway, with the rain still running off me onto her shoulder: I already did it.

PART TWO: WHAT FEAR COSTS

Before I tell you what fear cost me, I have to tell you about the instrument it played on, because they are not the same thing.

I am an empath. I am, in the clinical language I only found in my thirties and wept a little to find, a highly sensitive person, an HSP, which sounds like a delicate diagnosis and is actually closer to a different kind of nervous system entirely. The term isn't poetry; it's research. The psychologist Dr. Elaine Aron gave it a name in the nineties and a body of study underneath it: a real and measurable trait, found in something like one in five people, a brain that processes everything more deeply and feels everything more keenly and gets overwhelmed more easily for the simple reason that it is taking in more. I do not have skin so much as a screen door. The world comes straight through. I feel everything at a volume the world keeps calling a malfunction, and for most of my life I believed them, and tried, like turning down a stereo, to find the knob. There is no knob. I looked for years.

Let me show you what that actually means, on an ordinary day, because the words *empath* and *sensitive* have been worn so smooth they've stopped meaning anything. It means I can walk into a room and know, before a single word is spoken, that two people in it had a fight in the car. It means a stranger's grief three seats down on the train arrives in my own chest as a weight, real and physical, and I carry it home not knowing whose it is. It means a harsh light, a wool tag, a raised voice, a violent scene on a screen across a restaurant; these don't bother me the way they bother other people; they *bruise* me, the way a thumb bruises soft fruit. It means I cry at commercials and at the kindness of waiters and at the particular way late light falls across a kitchen floor, and that I have spent a great deal of energy, in a great many rooms, making sure no one ever saw me do it.

The philosophers, naturally, got there centuries before the psychologists, and I went looking for them too, the way I always do, three colors of ink at the ready. Edith Stein (who wrote her entire doctoral dissertation on the problem of empathy, *Einfühlung*, the act of feeling your way into another person) argued that this was not sentiment but a genuine form of *knowledge*, a real bridge across to another consciousness, and then she lived the argument all the way to its end: she became a Carmelite nun and, eventually, a saint, and died at Auschwitz, having decided that feeling-with was holy enough to die inside of. Walt Whitman put the empath's creed in one unbearable line: *I do not ask the wounded person how he feels, I myself become the wounded person.* I read it at twenty and thought, oh, that's not a poem, that's a medical chart, that's me on the train. And Simone Weil, who I love most and understand least, wrote that attention, taken to its very highest degree, is the same thing as prayer: that to give someone your full, undefended attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity there is. I read them all. I underlined them in three colors of ink, and I can report, after years of research, that knowing your sensitivity is a named trait studied by psychologists and praised by saints and sung by poets does precisely nothing, on a Tuesday, to make the train quieter. But it does something else, slower, that I'll get to.

Because here is the cost, the one that ran underneath everything. For most of my life I was told, gently, by people who loved me, and not so gently by people who didn't, to toughen up. To stop taking things so personally. To grow thicker skin, as though skin were the problem and not the gift. So I built the armor myself, plate by plate, and I called the armor *being fine*, and I learned to perform a calm I never once felt. And the feeling I refused at the surface didn't go anywhere. It went *down*, into the body. An empath who is taught to be ashamed of her own wiring doesn't become less sensitive. She just becomes sensitive in secret, and exhausted, and alone with the volume turned all the way up and nobody allowed to hear it.

And that secret sensitivity is exactly where fear moves in and signs a lease.

For as long as I can remember, fear and I share an apartment. It never pays rent and somehow always controls the thermostat. I meet it most nights around two in the morning, when the place has gone quiet and ticking and I am the only one awake to keep it company. And here's the trick of it, the thing that keeps it in business: it never once shows up looking like fear. It comes dressed as being responsible. As being realistic. As simply not getting my hopes up, so they can't be dashed later. It wears the good sober suit of maturity, and for years I mistake it for wisdom, when underneath the suit it's only ever a small shrieking animal absolutely certain that I am about to die.

It takes me a long time, I'm still, some mornings, working this out, to understand that I am not afraid of any one nameable thing. I am afraid of *existing*, and existing turns out to be a fear with a thousand outfits. There's the fear of being annihilated, of the lights going out mid-sentence. There's its exact opposite, the fear of *continuing*, of all these years stacked ahead of me like dishes piled to the ceiling. There's the fear of being known, of letting one person see the unedited me and watching them reach quietly for their coat, and its cruel twin, the fear of never being known at all, of moving through my one and only life as a rumor of myself. Kierkegaard calls freedom a kind of dizziness, the vertigo you feel at the cliff-edge of everything you might still become. Jung says the thing you are most afraid to turn and look at is, almost always, the exact thing you most need to pick up and carry home. Augustine, fifteen centuries ago, writes the truest sentence about anxiety I've ever found: *our heart is restless until it rests in You*. Restless. Like a body that can't get comfortable in any position in the bed.

Here's the part that still makes me laugh, the kind of laugh that loosens something stuck in the chest. The single most repeated instruction in the entire Bible is some version of *do not be afraid*. People like to say it lands three hundred and sixty-five times, one for every day of the year, and I suspect whoever first counted was also avoiding something, but the point

holds, and it floors me every time. The most frequent thing the divine ever bothers to say to us is not *behave*. It is not *believe the correct things in the correct order*. It is closer to: *easy. Breathe. I've got this one.*

We did not take the note. We built the evening news. Then the push notification. Then the comment section, where fear is no longer a roommate but a public utility, piped into every hand on every train.

I think about Jonah more than is probably healthy. Handed an assignment he doesn't want, he doesn't argue; he goes straight to the harbor, books passage on a boat pointed at the precise opposite edge of the map, and tries to outrun the whole of heaven. He is the patron saint of everyone who has ever left a hard conversation on read. And the joke of his story, the part that genuinely undoes me, is that he washes up *exactly where he was always meant to be*, only later, and by way of three days inside a fish, and so much the worse for the detour.

That's running, in the end. It works for a while. It genuinely works, right up until the night you're sitting in the dark, in the belly of something you cannot name, with no memory of how you got in. And running has a price, and the price is not abstract. There is a season I am not okay in a way that leaves metaphor behind and moves straight into the flesh. The fear, refused at the mouth, finds another way out. It comes out as the insomnia: the long ticking hours after two, the streetlight laid in a bar across the ceiling. It comes out as a chest that won't unclench, a breath that only ever makes it halfway down. It comes out as a gray film laid over everything I used to love, the strange flat sensation of watching my own life through a window someone painted shut from the outside. The mind sends its unpaid bills straight down to the body, and the body (loyal, uncomplaining, a little stupid in its devotion) always, always pays. It keeps every single receipt.

I had built an entire self out of being fine. It was the finest, most polished work I had ever done. It was also, quietly and without any drama at all, killing me, which is a strange and humbling thing to have to write about something you'd mistaken for a personality trait. I did not know yet that

being fine was about to be made obsolete by twelve women and a circle of chairs. I did not know yet that the cure for being alone with the volume was simply, finally, to let someone else into the room while it played.

PART THREE: THE TURNING POINT

This is the part I had backward for so long. And having it backward is exactly what nearly keeps me out on that sidewalk for good.

When Lazarus comes out of the tomb, there's a detail I miss for years. He comes out *alive*, and still wrapped, head to foot, in the grave clothes. Still bound. Still trailing the linen of the place he just left, still smelling of it, blinking in light he'd given up on. And the instruction Jesus gives is not *wonderful, you're breathing, sort the rest out yourself*. The instruction, spoken to the ordinary people standing right there in the daylight, the friends, the family, the neighbors, is this: *unbind him, and let him go*.

Sit with the division of labor in that for a second, because it rearranged my whole life. The miracle got him out of the grave. The *people who loved him* got him out of the wrappings. He could not, for all the resurrection in the world, unwind himself. Somebody had to come close, close enough to smell the tomb, and do it with their own hands. I had always thought reaching for help was the white flag, the gesture you make once you've conclusively failed at being strong. It is the opposite. It is the *second half of the resurrection*, the part where the people who love you crowd in close and begin, with their own warm hands, to unwind the linen. I am not ashamed of needing that anymore. It might be the truest thing I know.

And here is where I get to tell you the good part. Here is where I get to tell you what I actually walked into, because the stigma spends so much breath on what it imagines is inside that room, and not one word on the truth of it.

It's called *Walking with Purpose*, and it's simpler than anything I'd braced for. There's no stage. No expert. No one performing certainty down at us from a height. There's a circle of chairs and a book and two hours. We take

a chapter at a time, one for each Saturday, and we talk about it the way women talk when nobody is keeping score: slowly, honestly, doubling back, comparing our maps of the same hard country, admitting where the map went blank. It is never really about the verses, though we read them and come to love them. It is about twelve women telling the truth in a warm room.

And what I got from those Saturdays is the thing I most want to put in your hands, because it is the thing I had given up on. I got friends. Not acquaintances, not pleasant churchy contacts: friends, the real and durable kind, the kind I genuinely believed had stopped being issued to women my age. My phone, which for years had been a delivery system for dread, started lighting up midweek for an entirely new reason: a thread that never quite goes quiet, a casserole of prayer requests and small hard-won victories and somebody's kid's good news and somebody else's bad scan and a photo of a sunrise somebody pulled over on the highway to catch. Someone texts *thinking of you* on a Tuesday for no reason at all and means it. We learn each other's hard anniversaries and we show up for them. We sit in hospital parking lots. We stand in the church lot after the session has long ended, coats on, breath fogging, and talk for another hour because none of us wants to be the first to leave. I came for a book study. I stayed because I had, without quite noticing the moment it happened, fallen in love with a dozen people.

That's the word I kept circling and finally just set down on the table where we could both look at it: love. Not the abstract kind from the greeting cards. The specific kind. Acceptance with no audition. Encouragement with no invoice. The plain, almost unbearable mercy of being *believed the first time*. Being handed not a verdict but a chair. I had filed Bible study under judgment, under brittle certainty, under a kind of airless, lemon-scented, performed goodness. What I found was the photographic negative of every bit of it: the least judgmental room I have ever sat in, full of women who lead with their doubt instead of their answers, who hand you their messy

margins instead of their conclusions, who love you while you're still wrapped head to foot in the linen and don't wait for you to be presentable first.

And this is the mission, so let me say it straight to you, reader to reader, because it's the reason I'm writing at all: *the stigma is a lie, and it is a lie that keeps people out in the rain.* It kept me out for years. It is, right now, this minute, keeping somebody you know standing at the bottom of their own set of steps, rehearsing their own reasonable speech, certain they are the wrong kind of person for a room that has a chair open for them specifically, a room full of exactly the friendship and the love and the welcome they have privately, aching, given up on. The lie isn't harmless. It costs people the precise thing I almost lost. If this book does one thing, let it walk down the steps to whoever's standing there, take them by the cold hand, and tell them the truth about what's inside: it's warmer than you think, and you are wanted there, and you are already late for people who will love you.

But the thing I least expected, the thing I want to dwell on, because it is the whole turn of my life, is what all that love did to me. It brought me *back.* I have to use the plain word: reinvigorated. I was a gray, flat, painted-shut version of myself when I climbed those steps, running on the fumes of *fine,* and somewhere across those Saturdays the color came back into the world the way it comes back into your hands after you've been out too long in the cold: that hot, almost painful return of feeling. I started sleeping again, whole nights, the two-in-the-morning shift finally relieved of its lone watchwoman. I started laughing in that room, the real kind that bends you over the table. And (this is the one that undoes me) I started writing again. The poet I'd locked in the corner with her arms crossed got up and came back to the desk, because for the first time in years I had something other than fear to report from. You cannot pour from gray. These women ungrayed me. They handed my own life back to me with the lights on.

It took me most of my life to learn the difference between faith and certainty. I'd always treated them as one thing, faith as a destination you finally reach and plant a flag on and get to feel quietly superior about. But

certainty is not faith. **Certainty is just fear in a better coat.** Faith is what you do *while your hands are still shaking.* Faith is walking toward the thing you cannot yet see and trusting the floor to come up and meet your foot in the dark. I learn that in a circle of folding chairs, from women who have far more reason than I do to be sure of everything, and who have decided, instead, to keep showing up unsure, together, on purpose. *All you need is faith the size of a mustard seed,* the old line goes, a seed so small you could lose it in the lines of your own palm. For years I hear that as a low bar set out of pity. Now I think it's the most generous arithmetic in the world. You do not need a mountain of belief. You need a crumb. I had a crumb. The women had a warm room and a circle with exactly one seat still open and the patience to wait while I found it. Grace, I'm learning, never once asks for my qualifications. It never even glances at the form.

This is where faith stops being a feeling and turns into a paradox, the truest, hardest thing those women teach me. It is, at the very same time, the easiest and the most impossible thing a person can hold. Easy, because a crumb will do, because the entire entry fee is that you turn around. And impossible, daily impossible, because of what it asks *next.* It asks me to surrender. All the way down. I used to use that word as if it were soft, a spa word, a candle scent. It is not soft. Surrender means prying my own white knuckles, one finger at a time, off a wheel I have gripped since I was small, and trusting something higher and wiser and far less anxious than me to drive. I am a rank beginner at it, clumsy, grabbing the wheel back out of plain animal habit every ten minutes. But I have felt, in flashes, what it does when it works. The unclench. The sudden, clean, almost frightening quiet of a problem I finally set down because I decided, against all instinct, that it was never mine to carry alone, and, more to the point, because I finally had people to help me carry it.

PART FOUR: REBECOMING, IN PRACTICE

Theory is easy to write. What it costs to live it is a different book entirely, and this is where mine has to turn concrete, because faith never once comes to me as a voice from a cloud. It comes wearing faces. The faces in that circle on Saturdays. And, underneath them, holding them up, the faces of the specific, stubborn people who refused, across years and even across death, to let go of me.

Start with my mother, because she's where I start. My mother knew me before I had a self to show anyone. Before the campaigns and the comebacks and the carefully maintained *fine*. Before the first follower and the first fear. I am a grown woman now, with a profession and strong opinions about font kerning and the morally correct way to load a dishwasher, and to her, none of that is the point and none of it ever was. There is a particular grace in being loved by someone who knew you before you built a personality to perform. She does not love the latest model. She never wanted the upgrade, never asked for the new features. She loves the original (scratches, dents, factory defects and all) and she has never once, in my whole life, asked me to revise it before she'd accept it. When I think about what unconditional means, I don't reach for a definition. I reach for her face. She is the first proof I ever had that the love I found in that church basement was real, because I'd already had a small, lifelong sample of it at home.

Then there is my father, and his is a harder story to tell, because for most of my life I didn't have one to tell about him at all. My parents divorced when I was four. He moved to Arizona, and for twenty-five years he was less a father than a fact, a man at the far brown edge of the map of my life. I didn't hate him. You can't really hate a rumor.

What finally brings him back is the worst thing. In April 2017, my best friend Rob dies, falling an inch off a ladder. You can write that sentence as many times as you like and it never once starts to make sense. An inch. A whole irreplaceable man, gone over the length of a thumb. My father sees it on Facebook, of all the absurd and ordinary places, and he sends me a message to say he's sorry for my loss. I sit with that little gray bubble glowing on my screen for a long, long time. And then I do the one thing about this entire story I will never have to regret. I decide I do not want to feel *this* again, this exact tearing, on the day *he* dies, with twenty-five years of unsaid things still locked in the dark room between us. So I write back.

And for the next year, we make up for all of it at once. We text and call every single day, like two schoolgirls passing notes under the desk, like we are trying to spend a whole quarter-century of words before some clock neither of us can see runs all the way down. He's a retired FDNY firefighter and a grandmaster Mason out there in the Arizona heat, and he becomes, of all the unlikely things on this green earth, my best friend. We make a plan. I'll move out there. I'll start over near him, finally, and we'll take whatever years are left in the account and fill them right up to the brim.

And here's the regret I will carry into my own grave, so I'm going to set it down plainly and let it stand without excuse. I did not get on the plane. I stayed in New York and I guarded my boxes and my lease and my furniture as though any of it could keep a person warm, telling myself there was time, there was always going to be time. I chose the weight I knew over the leap I didn't. He died before I fixed it. I have spent this whole book talking about surrender, about prying my fingers off the wheel, and the plain, unsoftened truth is that I learned the cost of refusing to in the single most expensive way there is.

The night before he dies, we're on the phone for four hours. It's four in the morning, New York time, when I finally hang up, and I sit there in the dark afterward with the strangest, warmest thought arriving fully formed in my chest: *wow. You actually have a father who loves you.* That night he tells me a story I have never heard. Years before I was born, working a fire, he was

overcome by carbon monoxide and dropped into a coma, and while he was under, he had a near-death experience. He saw the light, and in the light he saw his uncle Norman, a tugboat captain. The same uncle who, when my father was a small boy, had told him he could fly because he was wearing a Superman cape. He'd seen Norman appear to him once before, too, on the very day Norman died in a tugboat fire, before a single soul had come to say the words out loud. To my father, none of this is a misfire of an oxygen-starved brain. To him it is proof, plain as a hand on a shoulder, that the people who go on ahead of us are not gone. Only out of sight. Only in the next room, with the door not quite latched.

And before we hang up, I confess something to him. I tell him I don't know what my purpose is. He doesn't even pause. He says, *"Well, ya got a great story, kid. Ya just need to tell it."*

The next day, the fourteenth of April, 2018, a massive heart attack takes him, all at once, with no warning and no goodbye beyond the one we didn't know we'd already said. The last whole thing my father ever hands me is an instruction that I am, at this exact moment, in the only way I know how, finally carrying out. You are holding it.

I see him now in numbers. He died on the fourteenth of the fourth, and ever since, 414 finds me everywhere: on clocks, on receipts, on license plates, in the corners of unrelated days, turning up so often it stops feeling like noticing and starts feeling like being greeted. There's another, 444, that belongs to my grandmother, and that one finds me too. People are welcome to call it coincidence if they need to. But I have stopped needing it to be. I call them my angel numbers. I call them mail.

Because the other face faith wears, the one I've carried longest, belongs to my grandmother. Ju Ju. She passed last November, and all these months later I am still, sentence by sentence, learning how to build a clause with her inside the past tense. It doesn't fit. My mouth won't make the shape. Her faith was the quiet kind: never performed, only lived, threaded so finely through the ordinary hours of her days that after a while you stopped seeing the thread at all and saw only the warmth it was quietly holding

together. She was also the first person on this whole earth to believe in my writing, back when there was nothing yet to believe *in*, when it was all just promise and bad first drafts and a girl who felt too much. She told me, more than once, looking right into me, that I was a great writer. She didn't say it the way you offer a comfort to a child. She said it the way you state a fact about the weather out the window. This book exists because of her. And she will never get to hold it. I have to hold both of those at once, and some days I can, and some days I cannot.

When I was small, my mother and Ju Ju and I used to go to the cemetery, the same cemetery where Ju Ju is buried now. While they tended the people they'd come to visit, I would run loops around a statue of the Blessed Mother, all that little-girl energy circling her calm, bowed, weather-softened head. The grave that holds Ju Ju now sits directly across from that same statue. I did not arrange that. I do not know who did. It was pouring the day I went looking for her, the cemetery unfolding like a small flooded city, row after gray row, the grass gone to standing water, the sky the exact color of the stones, and I went through it in the rain with the water running down my face until I genuinely could not tell anymore which of it was the sky and which of it was me. And somewhere in all that water I found her name. Across from the Blessed Mother. Right where the circle I'd been running as a child finally, quietly closed.

I remember her last hours with a clarity that frightens me a little. We prayed the rosary. I can still feel the whole rhythm of it living in my hands, the smooth cool beads moving one by one through my fingers, the repetition that somewhere across the decades stops being repetition at all and becomes a kind of shared breathing. I held her hand in both of mine, and we prayed, and I will spend the rest of my life grateful beyond saying that the last language between us was that one. The oldest one. The first one she ever taught me. We ended where we began.

There is an old, stubborn idea in my church called the communion of saints, the notion that everyone who has ever loved you, the living and the long gone alike, belongs to one single body, and that they go on holding you up *together*, across the whole distance of time, hand over hand over

hand. I am not theologian enough to defend it in an argument. But I am experienced enough now to know it in my own chest. My father is in that communion. My grandmother is in it. Rob is in it. And (this is what those Saturdays taught me) so are the living. The dozen women in the circle are pews too: the quiet structure underneath, the thing that keeps you upright and facing forward on the mornings your own legs stop agreeing to. I feel the grip of it most on Saturdays, and at 4:14, and at 4:44, and in the rain. And I mean Biggie too: my dog, asleep through every word of this, possibly a minor angel, possibly just a dog, and I get less convinced by the year that there's any difference. He heals me daily by needing his dinner, reliably and indignantly, at five.

I used to believe I was self-made. I said it from podiums like it was a virtue. It was a lie, the kind we tell from podiums precisely because it sounds so good out loud. I am held up, in every single moment, by a hundred small unglamorous hands. Some of them stopped being attached to anyone breathing years ago, and they hold me anyway. And some of them texted me back this morning.

PART FIVE: THE LATEST MODEL

So. Here we are. Who am I now.

Not the woman who stood at the bottom of the steps for eleven minutes, terrified of a lit and entirely harmless door. Not quite her anymore. And yet (and this is the part I never once saw coming) also, somehow, completely her.

I had assumed healing would turn me into someone else. A different woman. An upgrade so total and so clean that I'd lose the old one entirely in the swap, and good riddance. I was almost looking forward to it, the way you look forward to the last page of a chapter you've hated. *Good riddance to her,* I thought. The scared one. The fine one. The one out on the sidewalk in the rain with her hands going numb around a folding bulletin.

That is not what happens. What happens is harder to fit on a book jacket and a thousand times truer to live inside. I do not become someone else. I become *her again,* the woman I'd been long before fear talked me, slowly and so reasonably, into making myself smaller and quieter and easier to carry around. The poet. The loud one. The empath who feels everything at a volume the world keeps calling a malfunction, and who has finally decided that the volume was never the bug. The volume was the gift the entire time. I get her back. Same soul. Same wiring. The latest model.

You do not put new wine into old wineskins, the old line warns, because the new wine keeps fermenting and swelling and breathing, and in time it splits the brittle old skin right down the side. For most of my life I read that as a story about *replacement.* Out with the old, in with the new. Now I read it as a story about *capacity,* and it stops my breath every time. You do not get a brand-new self handed to you, clean and shrink-wrapped, at the door.

You get a self finally grown big enough, and supple enough, and soft enough, to hold, without bursting, everything that was always already alive inside you.

That is what I mean by the word. Rebecoming is not erasing who you were. It is *recovering* her. It is finding her right where you left her, in the dark, at the bottom of the steps, arms crossed in the corner, and at long last building her a bigger room. The resurrection, stripped all the way down to the frame, is the most audacious reinvention story ever told, and we've let the stigma convince us it's a story for a certain kind of person. It isn't. It's the same person who went into the tomb who comes back out. The same wounds, even, still open enough to put a hand into. And yet more alive than before. That's the model I'm working from. Not a clean swap. Not a factory reset. A return. A coming-back. With every scar deliberately, defiantly left in, because the scars were never the damage. **The scars are the proof.**

I think, at the end, about the woman at the well, because she is the whole mission in a single afternoon, and I didn't understand that until I'd lived it. She's the one everybody had written off. The wrong kind of woman, with the wrong kind of history, coming to draw water at noon, in the worst of the heat, specifically so she wouldn't have to face the other women at the cooler hours. The outsider's outsider. And she's the one, *her*, not the certain ones, not the qualified ones, not the row of judges I'd invented and feared, who drops her water jar and runs back into the town and tells everyone. She becomes the first to spread the word. The least likely person in the story carries it the farthest. I read that now and I think: of course. Of course it's her. It's the only way the thing ever travels: hand to hand, outsider to outsider, one un-grayed woman running back to tell the next one that the water's real.

I am still afraid sometimes. I want to be honest about that, here at the end, because every book that swears the fear leaves for good is selling the same lie the algorithm sells, only now with a cross on the cover and a higher price at the register. The fear still comes around. It still knocks at two in the morning. The only difference now, and it is the difference that remade my entire life, is that it no longer controls the thermostat. It knocks,

and I open the door, and I pull out a chair and let it sit and say its whole anxious piece. And then it goes. It doesn't get to stay the night anymore. That bed is mine, and the room around it is full now: full of friends, full of the living and the dead who love me, full, at long last, of hope I no longer have to ration.

I traded fear for faith. Not, in the end, by getting rid of the fear, but by growing, slowly and with an enormous and humbling amount of help, *bigger* than it. By learning, one ordinary Saturday morning at a time, to peel my own fingers off the wheel. By building a self out of a scanned QR code and an angel's arms in a doorway and a stranger's ink-crowded margins and a grandmother's worn rosary and a father's last four-hour phone call and an unbothered dog and a dozen women who held the door and then refused to let me leave, a self finally roomy enough to hold all that fear and keep walking forward anyway, in good company, in the light.

The last thing my father ever gave me was a sentence. *You got a great story, kid, you just need to tell it.* I couldn't find my purpose the night he asked me for it. I've come to believe it was hiding inside his answer the whole time. It was never a title. Never a job. It was just this: telling the truth out loud until it reaches whoever needs it next. Until it walks down the steps to the person standing at the bottom in the rain.

So let me walk down to you, since that's the whole job. If you are standing where I stood, at the bottom of some set of steps, in some kind of weather, with a reasonable speech ready and a costume of good reasons buttoned to the chin and a door that feels much farther than forty feet, hear me. Somebody told you that room wasn't for you. Somebody told you what kind of woman walks through it, and let you believe you weren't her. That was the lie. I cannot walk up the steps for you; that part has only ever had one set of feet. But I can tell you, from the inside, exactly what's on the other side of that door: not certainty, not a clean fix, not a row of judges. A warm room. A candle going somewhere you can't see yet. A chair with your name on it. Friendships you've stopped believing get issued to someone your age. Love with no audition. And a leader who will cross the floor like the dawn and put her arms around you before you've even said your name.

Find your version of the steps. Stand at the bottom as long as you need to. And then, go up anyway. You are already late for people who are going to love you.

I am still a draft. You caught me mid-revision; you can probably see the pencil marks. I am still a long way off, still on the road, still, most mornings, a little afraid. But I get up. I scan the code, I climb the steps, I walk in. And I have finally, finally stopped pretending I'm doing any of it alone.

♡ MK

REBECOMING: THE LATEST MODEL

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